Parental School Choice in the Hmong Community

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TRiO
RONALD E. McNAIR POST-BACCALAUREATE ACHIEVEMENT PROGRAM

"With the charter schools, we decided not to go with them just because I didn't know if I trust the quality of the education."

"We chose a Hmong school for our child because they do not speak English."

"I want my child's school to have a homework center, even if it's after school, I'm willing to drive and pick them up."

Introduction

Overview: We explore Hmong mothers' choice of school for their kindergarten child for the fall of 2010 by examining the factors and resources they used in the process.

School Choice: The Minnesota school choice option allows parents the "power and opportunity to choose the school their child will attend" (The Center for Education Reform, 2009) and 30% of all MN parents take advantage of the school choice option (MN Department of Education, 2010).

Literature indicates 12 factors that impact kindergarten school choice including the school's success record, class size and student population characteristics (George & Wilson, 1992). Other research found several educational issues influencing Hmong parents' views on American education including after school activities, expectations of teachers, and a "tightly controlled classroom" (Timm, 1994).

The Tension:
Importance of Educational Attainment: Most Hmong immigrated to America seeking better educational opportunities for future generations. They view education as the "means to economic success in the United States" (Timm, 1994) and most parents are concerned with their children's education (Vang, 2004).

Cultural Perspective/Experience with Parental Role in Education: Hmong parents worry their children will lose their culture by attending American schools (Timm, 1994). However, many limit their parental school involvement to only providing basic needs for their children because they believe their school involvement is non-essential (Lee, 2008; Ngo, Bigelow & Wahlstrom, 2007 & Timm, 1994).



Research Questions

1. What factors do Hmong parents use when selecting a school for their kindergarten child?

2. What resources do Hmong parents use in the school choice process?

Preliminary Results

Top Rated Factors
- ✓ Test Scores
- ✓ Presence of Hmong Staff
- ✓ School Climate
- ✓ Extracurricular Activities
- ✓ Other Children In Family Attending Same School

Most Important Factor Used: Word of Mouth

Most Helpful Resource Used: Family and Friends

"I want the schools to have a partnership with the Hmong parents. I want them to help us make decisions, help our children with their homework, discipline them and I think there should be a law about this."

Methods

Participants : Convenience sample of five Hmong mothers with children entering kindergarten in fall of 2010 in the Twin Cities area.

Theoretical Perspective: Rational choice theory

Data Collection:
Interview: Open ended & multiple choice questions

EXAMPLE

1. What language(s) do you speak?
2. What resources did you use in the school choice process?

Survey: Examines what resources and factors parents used in the school choice process.

EXAMPLE

Rate how important these factors are to you:

1 = Very Important
2 = Important
3 = Moderately Important
4 = Of Little Importance
5 = Unimportance

a) Presence of Hmong Staff..... 1 2 3 4 5
b) School Neighborhood..... 1 2 3 4 5

Data Analysis:
Open coding system (Strauss & Corbin)

Discussion & Implications

- **Initial results suggest** parents view educational decisions as important factors for achievement and becoming "Americanized".

- **More research needed** in this area of study. Suggested topics to further explore are: Hmong decision making, intergenerational issues, and parental school involvement.